



Since 2017, he has had the highest number of passes among midfielders in five seasons. This year was no different, as he registered 1367 successful passes, 369 more than the next best, while playing two games fewer.

Even though Odisha did not win the ISL Shield or the ISL title with Jahouh in its fold, the Juggernauts were legitimate contenders, leading the points table during the season and reaching the semifinals for the first time. It also reached the AFC Cup Inter-Zone semifinals and narrowly lost the Super Cup final.

ISL'S FOREIGNER RULES HAVE PROMPTED TEAMS TO LOOK ABROAD FOR RESOURCES WHO CAN RAISE THE TECHNICAL LEVEL OF THEIR SIDE

But one wonders if there is an Indian midfielder who can replicate or surpass Jahouh's abilities on the ball.

FC Goa's Brandon Fernandes is

perhaps the only one who possesses a technique comparable to Jahouh's. However, unlike the latter, Brandon is an attacking midfielder.

When Igor Stimac took over as the national team coach in 2019, he emphasised moving away from a long ball-oriented approach to a possession-based one, building attacks by passing from the back.

His preferred system is either 4-2-3-1 or 4-4-2, both of which require two central midfielders to play an integral role in breaking up play while funnelling possession from the backline and circulating it towards the attacking third of the pitch.

"We have improved our passing accuracy and possession; we have become more technical," Stimac noted in 2021. Luckily for him, his tenure coincided with ISL teams adopting a possession-heavy style, with coaches from Spain, Germany, and the UK implementing this approach.

But does India have enough midfielders who can implement this style? The ISL's 3+1 foreigner rule

Old is gold: Even at 35, Janouh's (yellow) mastery continues to leave many spellbound. K. MURALIKUMAR

Powerhouse of promise: Brandon Fernandes (left) is perhaps the only one who possesses a technique comparable to that of Ahmed Jahouh, ISL's best midfielder. PTI

In his seven ISL seasons, the Moroccan has made a significant impact across three teams: FC Goa and Mumbai City FC (both of which won the ISL Shield and multiple ISL championships with him pulling strings in the midfield), and Odisha FC, the latest beneficiary of his arrival on the east coast.

